

Teaching Statement

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My teaching is grounded in curiosity, clarity, and care. Whether in theory, analysis, or composition, I want students to experience music as something that belongs to them: a medium through which to think, to make, and to connect. Teaching, for me, is a creative act—an extension of the same processes of exploration and reflection that animate my composition and research. I aim to model a balance of intellectual rigor and imaginative freedom, encouraging students to approach music as an integral part of the wider tapestry of human inquiry: literature, philosophy, history, mathematics, and science.

At Duke, I have designed and delivered courses both independently and collaboratively, developed and graded assessments, and led lessons and courses. I have taught *Music 161: Introduction to Music Theory*, *Music 261L: Theory and Practice of Tonal Music*, and *Music 273S: Introduction to Electronic Music Composition* as instructor of record, contributed significant guest lectures to *Nineteenth-Century Music* and *Musical Shakespeare*, and twice assisted in the *Introduction to Electronic Music* course.

I use backward course design, beginning with learning goals and objectives, then planning meaningful assessments and activities that support them. I regard each syllabus I have written as a living document, revised through reflection, classroom experience, and peer observation. I emphasize transparency and accessibility—clear expectations, inclusive content, and diverse learning resources. For example, in *Music 161* I introduced scaffolding strategies for new learners and redesigned assessments to make the rationale for each assignment explicit. For my own syllabus, *Songs of the Earth: Music in a Time of Climate Crisis*, I combined creative and critical approaches to the climate crisis but upon reflection and discussion with a senior colleague diversified the content covered to improve representation across the course.

Active learning underpins my teaching. In *Music 261L* I used “one-minute papers” to identify shared challenges and shape future lessons. In *Music 161* an anonymous online portal allowed students to submit questions before the midterm, while a collaborative playlist assignment encouraged stylistic diversity and peer discussion around identity and genre. In a guest lecture on Schumann’s *Dichterliebe*, students drew poems from a “lucky dip,” imagined their own settings, and then compared them to Schumann’s—an approach blending history, imagination, and collective reflection.

I see feedback as central to learning, not an afterthought, balancing formative and summative assessment, peer review, drafts, and dialogue to scaffold growth. My feedback is timely, selective, and specific. Anonymous course evaluations note that I am “very engaging and ready to work with” students and that “the way Chris helped us practise for specific skills was exceptional.”

Teaching is, finally, a reciprocal act. My students’ development and my own are intertwined; reflection, feedback, and professional learning continually reshape my practice. I aim to create classrooms where curiosity, creativity, and intellectual openness thrive—values that produce and contribute to a vibrant, collaborative musical community.